

Personalized AI assistants could either promote or hinder the emergence of collective intelligence

Jaeseung Kim¹ Sang Woo Park^{1,2,3,*}

¹ School of Biological Sciences, Seoul National University, Seoul, Korea

² Department of Ecology and Evolution, University of Chicago, Chicago, IL, USA

³ Department of Ecology and Evolutionary Biology, Princeton University, Princeton, NJ, USA

*Corresponding author: sangwoopark@snu.ac.kr

Abstract

Advances in artificial intelligence (AI) have enabled the wide use of personalized assistance for cognitive tasks, which enhanced individual performance on various fields. However, the impact of AI assistance on collective intelligence remains poorly understood. AI assistance may undermine the emergence of collective intelligence by reducing the individual diversity or introducing structured biases into a population. Here, we develop a human-AI collective prediction model mediated by social learning based on incentive structure by extending the existing works on collective intelligence. Our model uncovers that emergence of collective intelligence is depend on how human and AI interact. When AI works as if it is omniscient and gives assistance regardless of users' interests, collective intelligence will be promoted. However, when AI works as a chat-bot and gives assistance only based on users' interests, collective intelligence could be hindered due to diversity loss and overconfidence on AI. We showed that, to promote collective intelligence, penalizing or incentivizing AI usage is not reliable. Instead, elaborating more diversity-aware incentives could be the key to promote and maintain the collective intelligence.

Introduction

Collective intelligence (CI) describes a phenomenon in which a group’s ability to solve problems, make decisions, or adapt to changing environments exceeds each member’s ability [1, 2, 3, 4, 5]. This phenomenon, also referred to as wisdom of crowds, has thus served as a central mechanism underlying the success of diverse organizations, ranging from animal groups [6, 7, 8] and human societies [2, 9] to machine-learning systems [10, 11]. Understanding the conditions that promote and maintain CI therefore remains a fundamental question across social sciences [12], evolutionary biology [13], and computer science [14]. Addressing this question has become particularly timely as artificial intelligence (AI) has begun to reshape how individuals acquire information, make decisions, and contribute to collective outcomes [15].

The recent emergence of generative AIs and large language models (LLMs) has changed the way individuals engage in various cognitive tasks, ranging from simple everyday tasks to more complex tasks, including scientific discovery [16] and creative writing [17]. In particular, while the use of personal AI models, such as ChatGPT, has been rapidly increasing [18], the potential long-term impact of personal AI services on human society, especially the CI, remains uncertain. Some argue that AI can promote CI by enhancing individual expertise [19], and opinion aggregation [20]. Conversely, empirical evidence indicate that the use of AIs can limit the diversity of opinions [17, 21, 22], a key requirement for the emergence of CI [23, 24, 25].

Our ability to predict the long-term impact of personal AI services on human CI is hampered by the apparent discrepancy in the incentives that shape AI uses. On one hand, many industrial sectors are pushing towards increased AI usages, where the number of “tokens” used is often perceived as a proxy for productivity [26, 27]. On the other hand, many academic institutions appear to discourage, and even penalize, AI use, reflecting concerns about plagiarism, misinformation, and limited independence [28, 29]. Such discrepancy raises a question about whether directly penalizing or incentivizing AI usage will benefit or harm human CI. These observations further highlight the importance of indentifying a robust incentive structure that can promote CI in the presence of AI, which can retain the benefits of AIs while preventing potential risk such as preserving the diversity of individual opinions.

To address these questions, we extended previous approaches for modeling CI, where each individual makes independent predictions for the outcome from partial observations of underlying causal factors [12, 13, 30]. We allowed each individual to independently consult with personal AIs and revise their predictions accordingly. Across different assumptions about the AI model’s ability and underlying incentive structures, we investigate the robustness of human CIs.

Main

Model

We began by extending previous models of CI in which a group of players makes collective predictions by gathering information and aggregating individual predictions in a decentralized manner [30, 12, 13]. In the previous approach, among M different factors (x_i) that affect the outcome (Y), each individual makes a prediction based on their factor of interest (x_{e_A}) and their own belief (c_A): $Y_A = c_A x_{e_A}$. Here, we assume each individual can independently consult AI and revise their prediction based on their reliance on AI (β_A): $Y_A^{re} = \beta_A Y_A^{AI} + (1 - \beta_A) Y_A$.

To specify how individuals consult AI, we model the AI prediction (Y_A^{AI}) as a noisy and biased estimate of the target outcome. Specifically, AI predictions include factor-specific bias (b_i) and stochastic error (ϵ). We then consider two extreme modes of AI response, which differ in the amount of information AI uses when consulting an individual user. The first is the “AI knows all” model, in which AI predicts the outcome based on all factors regardless of the user’s interest: $Y_A^{AI} = \sum_{i=0}^M (\alpha_i x_i + b_i) + \epsilon$, where α_i represents the true coefficient of the causal factor. The second is the “AI answers question” model, in which AI predicts the outcome based only on the user’s interest: $Y_A^{AI} = \alpha_{e_A} x_{e_A} + b_{e_A} + \epsilon$.

After the prediction, each individual is rewarded by the expected value of their payoff under the incentive structure. We adopt two incentive structures, “feedback” and “niche expert” from Wang et al. [13], which have been shown to promote near-perfect collective accuracy without AI (except averaging aggregation with niche expert incentive). The feedback incentive gives higher payoff to individuals who can push the collective prediction toward the true outcome, regardless of their individual predictive accuracy. By contrast, the niche expert incentive gives higher payoff to individuals who have both better individual predictive accuracy and a minority interest.

For each generation, two individuals are randomly sampled, and one imitates all three strategies (factor of interest, belief, reliance on AI) of the other with a probability determined by the difference in expected payoff. Individual predictions are aggregated into a collective prediction by simple averaging in the AI knows all model, or by clustering in the AI answers question model, depending on the mode of AI.

AI can both promote or prevent the emergence of CI

To understand how AI could affect the emergence of CI, we first compare collective dynamics with and without AI assistance. We adopt two simple incentive structures, “feedback” and “niche expert” from Wang et al. [13] as a baseline, have been shown to promote near-perfect collective accuracy without AI (except averaging aggregation with niche expert incentive). The AI was parameterized to have moderate predictive

103 performance, approximately 0.7.

104 We find that AI affects CI in qualitatively different ways depending on the mode
105 of AI. In the AI knows all model, AI promotes CI by increasing the speed at which
106 CI emerges or the resulting collective accuracy (Fig. 2A). When the population can
107 achieve near-perfect CI without AI (feedback incentive), AI accelerates its emergence
108 by raising the initial collective accuracy to the level of AI accuracy. By contrast,
109 when the population cannot achieve CI without AI (niche expert incentive), AI
110 enables moderately accurate CI that is more accurate than either the AI or the
111 human population can achieve alone.

112 However, In the AI answers question model, AI prevents the emergence and
113 maintenance of CI (Fig. 2B). Under the feedback incentive, the population initially
114 achieves near-perfect CI. However, as interest diversity rapidly decreases, collective
115 accuracy breaks down with an increase in collective variance. Under the niche expert
116 incentive, the initial increase in collective accuracy peaks before near-perfect CI is
117 achieved, and then plateaus with a slight decrease as collective bias increases.

118 **Directly incentivizing or penalizing AI usage**

119 **Balanced incentive for AI Era**

120 **Discussion**

121 We present an epidemiological analysis of RSV outbreaks in Japan combining spa-
122 tiotemporal observations with dynamical disease modeling. Our analysis revealed
123 semiannual cycles in seasonal RSV transmission in four major islands (Honshu,
124 Shikoku, Kyushu, and Ryukyu), which correlate with specific humidity and tem-
125 perature. We found that these semiannual cycles allowed a sudden shift in the
126 seasonality of RSV outbreaks in response to an increase in RSV transmission—this
127 increase could be captured by either through changes in susceptibility or transmissi-
128 bility. We hypothesize that an increase in childcare capacity through Comprehensive
129 Support System for Children and Childcare may have contributed to the increase in
130 RSV transmission [?].

131 Our analysis revealed considerable heterogeneity in epidemic dynamics across
132 major islands in Japan. We showed that these differences could be explained by
133 the differences in underlying seasonal transmission. Notably, we found a robust,
134 quadratic relationship between the estimated transmission rates against mean spe-
135 cific humidity and mean temperature across four major islands (Honshu, Shikoku,
136 Kyushu, and Ryukyu), indicating low transmission at intermediate levels of specific
137 humidity. These findings echo earlier studies that demonstrated similar relationships
138 for RSV [?] and influenza [? ? ? ? ?]. However, given strong correlation between
139 specific humidity and temperature, we were unable to identify the primary environ-
140 mental driver from the current study. Their relative contributions may be separated
141 from data spanning a wider geographical region with more climate variability as well

142 as epidemiological variability [?].

143 The robustness of this quadratic relationship across islands exhibiting different
144 climate conditions also suggests a possibility that climate-driven transmission may
145 be, in part, facilitated by human behavior: for example, an increase in time spent
146 indoors during low and high humidity seasons can contribute to increased transmis-
147 sion. Further investigation is needed to establish the underlying mechanism behind
148 how climate conditions affect the transmission of respiratory pathogens, especially
149 across different environmental contexts (e.g., indoor vs outdoor). We note that this
150 relationship is correlational, rather than causal, and therefore any other climate vari-
151 ables (e.g., rainfall) or seasonal variation in human behavior (e.g., school terms) that
152 correlate with seasonal variation in specific humidity and temperature will be implic-
153 itly captured by this relationship. Understanding why the relationship between RSV
154 transmission and humidity in Hokkaido island differs from other locations remains
155 to be answered.

156 We hypothesized that the Comprehensive Support System for Children and Child-
157 care may have contributed to the increase in RSV transmission, but other mecha-
158 nisms may have also contributed. For example, an increase in inbound overseas trav-
159 elers may have led to an increased exposure to RSV among adults thereby increasing
160 the total amount of transmission [?]. However, RSV typically infects young chil-
161 dren [?] and contact rates among young children and adolescents (5–19) are much
162 higher than among older adults in Japan [?], suggesting that an increase in
163 inbound overseas travelers may have smaller effects than an increase in childcare at-
164 tendance on overall RSV dynamics. Another competing hypothesis that could lead
165 to an increase in transmission would be strain evolution: for example, one study
166 noted that L172Q/S173L mutant strains of RSV B that became dominant around
167 2016 had reduced susceptibility against monoclonal antibodies [?]. However, it is
168 not yet clear how this mutation translates to susceptibility against infection-derived
169 antibodies. While our findings are consistent with those by [?], who also pointed
170 out the association between an increase in childcare attendance and a large change
171 in the seasonality of Kawasaki disease in Japan, we cannot rule out the possibility
172 that other factors, such as increase in air travel [?] or strain evolution [?], could
173 have contributed to the increase in overall transmission.

174 Our sensitivity analysis revealed that an increase in transmissibility, rather than
175 an increase in susceptibility, can also explain a sudden shift in seasonality in RSV
176 outbreaks. In fact, both models provide evidence for increased contact rates. Specif-
177 ically, the total rate of RSV transmission can be written as $\hat{\beta}cSI/N$, where $\hat{\beta}$ repre-
178 sents the rate of transmission per contact, c represents the contact rate, S represents
179 the number of susceptible individuals, I represents the number of infected individu-
180 als, and N represents the total population size. Then, an increase in contact rate c
181 can be captured by either increase in S (the original model) and $\hat{\beta}$ (the sensitivity
182 analysis). Therefore, conclusions from both models are consistent with our hypoth-
183 esis that an increase in contact rates, especially among children, contributed to the
184 sudden change in RSV seasonality. Detailed age structured surveillance data, along-

side age structured model, will be needed to properly assess the relative contribution of potential mechanisms, such as increase in childhood mixing patterns or increase in inbound overseas travelers.

Our model-based estimate of the initial susceptible fraction range between 8%–11%. However this estimate must be interpreted with care as it represents effective changes in population-level susceptibility, which can depend on many factors such as immunological and behavioral changes, rather than an actual susceptible fraction. Therefore, these estimates are not directly comparable to serological estimates of proportion seronegative. For example, [?] recently estimated that $\sim 90\%$ of individuals above 3 years of age have been infected at least once by analyzing anti-pre-F protein antibody concentration data from the Netherlands [? ?], but individuals with RSV antibodies can still permit reinfection. A cross-section serological assay from healthcare and non-healthcare workers at a pediatric medical facility in Japan found that $\sim 95\%$ of the participants were seropositive but only 63.5% had greater than 8 fold neutralizing antibody titers [?], suggesting challenges in translating serological data to susceptible fraction. While our estimates are not inconsistent with these data, detailed age structured serological data and model are needed to accurately estimate changes in population-level susceptibility against RSV.

Interventions to slow the transmission of COVID-19 have disrupted the circulation of many pathogens [? ? ? ?], including RSV epidemics in Japan. This disruption has added major challenges to predicting future outbreaks, which prevented us from making long-term predictions. Continued analysis of RSV dynamics in the post-COVID period, particularly with regard to whether RSV outbreaks in Japan return to fall or winter outbreaks, may help further validate our models.

Our analysis relied on several simplifying assumptions. For example, our model assumed that the waning of immunity can render previously infected individual to become fully susceptible to reinfections; this approximation allowed us to reconstruct the dynamics of susceptible hosts more easily. In practice, immunity is likely more complex with secondary infections being less susceptible and transmissible than primary infections [?]. Other studies have also suggested the importance of interaction between RSV A and B [? ?] as well as competition between RSV and human metapneumovirus [?]; our model did not account for such strain dynamics. We also did not account for explicit spatial structure or underlying stochasticity of the system. Therefore, our estimates of transmission rates must be interpreted with caution as they may implicitly capture factors that we did not account for explicitly, including strain dynamics, spatial structure, and exogenous transmission. Our analyses also primarily focused on three major islands (Honshu, Shikoku, and Kyushu), necessitating a better understanding of RSV dynamics in Hokkaido and Ryukyu islands; however, we note that these three islands make up $> 95\%$ of the population in Japan, meaning that our analyses capture the majority of RSV transmission in Japan. Despite these limitations, our model likely represents a parsimonious approximation of the complex host-pathogen interactions, allowing us to draw general conclusions about how interactions between endogenous (contact rates) and exoge-

nous (climate-driven factors) factors can give rise to a sudden dynamical transition. Understanding how endogenous and exogenous factors shape epidemic dynamics is critical to predicting future outbreaks and making public health decisions. Our analysis shows that the interplay between climate-driven transmission and subtle changes in contact rates can cause a sudden transition in epidemic dynamics. More broadly, our analysis demonstrates that detailed epidemiological time series data can allow us to tease apart endogenous and exogenous factors in explaining dynamical transitions, offering unique insights into a long-standing ecological question.

Methods

To model CI, we start with an abstract model that assumes the prediction target is the result of multiple causal factors [13]. Specifically, the prediction target Y is modeled as a linear combination of M independent factors $(x_1, x_2, \dots, x_m)$ and $M + 1$ coefficients $(\alpha_0, \alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_m)$, where α_0 denotes the global offset (Fig. 1A). The M factors are randomly drawn from normal distributions with mean X_i and standard deviation σ_i in each generation.

Among a population of N individuals, each individual can observe a single factor and make a prediction based on the observed value and their own belief. In particular, individual A 's prediction is modeled as:

$$Y_A = c_A x_{e_A} \quad (1)$$

where c_A represents individual A 's personal belief, e_A represents the factor that A observes (interest), and x_{e_A} represents the realized value of A 's interest. Individuals can also choose not to observe any factor, which represents stubborn individuals who make predictions only based on their own belief. For notational convenience, we assume that stubborn individuals have interest 0, and let x_0 always be 1.

Next, we model AI as a prediction system that has learned the true coefficients with bias and error (Fig. 1B). For each factor $i \in [0, M]$, AI knows the exact coefficient α_i and has a fixed bias b_i , resulting in a prediction of $\alpha_i x_i + b_i$. In terms of human-AI interaction, we model two contrasting modes of AI: the "AI knows all" model and the "AI answers question" model. In the AI knows all model, AI acts as an omniscient system and gives an answer regardless of the individual's interest, accounting for all factors related to the task. Thus, AI predicts as follows:

$$Y_A^{AI} = \sum_{i=0}^M (\alpha_i x_i + b_i) + \epsilon \quad (2)$$

In contrast, the AI answers question model acts as a chatbot and gives an answer only based on the individual's interest. Thus, given the individual's interest, e_A , AI predicts as follows:

$$Y_A^{AI} = \alpha_{e_A} x_{e_A} + b_{e_A} + \epsilon \quad (3)$$

261 In both models, $\epsilon \sim N(0, \sigma_e^2)$ represents random error arising from the stochastic
 262 generative process of the AI model.

263 AI works as a personalized assistant for each individual, such that each individual
 264 receives assistance by incorporating the AI’s prediction. However, even with the same
 265 opportunity to receive AI assistance, reliance on AI can vary substantially across
 266 individuals. To model this, we assume that the revised prediction is a weighted sum
 267 of the individual’s own prediction and the AI’s prediction by introducing AI belief
 268 β_A as a weighting coefficient. The revised prediction of individual A can be written
 269 as:

$$Y_A^{revised} = \beta_A Y_A^{AI} + (1 - \beta_A) Y_A \quad (4)$$

270 The revised predictions of individuals are aggregated by two different mechanisms,
 271 depending on the mode of AI. In the AI knows all model, even if an individual can
 272 observe only a single factor, their revised prediction contains information about all
 273 factors through interaction with AI. Therefore, we use simple averaging of revised
 274 predictions as the collective prediction. In contrast, in the AI answers question
 275 model, each individual gives a prediction based only on a single factor even after
 276 revising their prediction with AI assistance. Therefore, we use clustering aggregation
 277 to obtain the collective prediction, which is performed by clustering individuals based
 278 on interest and summing the average values of each cluster.

279 For each generation, each individual is rewarded with a payoff based on the given
 280 incentive structure (Fig. 1C). We adopt two incentive structures, “feedback” and
 281 “niche expert,” which were proposed by Wang et al. [13] and promote collective
 282 intelligence when prediction is performed without AI. The feedback incentive gives
 283 higher payoff to individuals who can push the collective prediction toward the true
 284 value, regardless of their individual performance. Given individual A ’s revised pre-
 285 diction $Y_A^{revised}$ and the collective prediction $\hat{Y}^{revised}$, it can be expressed as:

$$\pi_A = Y_A^{revised} (Y - \hat{Y}^{revised}) \quad (5)$$

286 The niche expert incentive gives higher payoff to individuals who have both better
 287 individual performance and a minority interest. Specifically, the niche expert payoff
 288 is expressed as the product of the proportion of individuals who observe the same
 289 factor as individual A , ρ_{e_A} , and individual accuracy. Given individual A ’s revised
 290 prediction $Y_A^{revised}$, it can be expressed as:

$$\pi_A = -\rho_{e_A} (Y_A^{revised} - Y)^2 \quad (6)$$

291 These two incentive structures were shown to achieve nearly perfect collective in-
 292 telligence through social learning (except for the niche expert incentive with simple
 293 averaging aggregation) by promoting individual expertise while maintaining collec-
 294 tive diversity. Therefore, we use these incentive structures as a baseline to under-
 295 stand how AI affects the emergence of collective intelligence. Moreover, we modify

the two baseline incentives in a later section to understand the consequences of direct incentives and penalties for AI usage.

Throughout the simulation, individuals engage in social learning by imitating other individuals who receive higher payoffs. We assume that prediction events occur more frequently than social learning events within the population, such that individual payoff can be computed as an expected payoff. The imitation process is performed for at most one pair in each generation. By sampling two random individuals, A and B , imitation is performed with probability:

$$\frac{1}{1 + \exp(s(\mathbb{E}[\pi_A] - \mathbb{E}[\pi_B]))} \quad (7)$$

where s denotes the strength of social learning. When imitation occurs, A imitates all three strategies of B : interest, belief, and AI belief.

To evaluate and analyze the dynamics of collective prediction, we define six summary metrics: collective accuracy, collective bias, collective variance, human accuracy, interest diversity, and median AI belief. These metrics capture the accuracy of the revised collective prediction, its bias-variance decomposition, the predictive performance without AI, the diversity of individual interests, and median AI belief in the population (Table 1).

Simulations

We run a series of simulations to understand how the interplay between climate-driven transmission and population-level susceptibility can drive a sudden shift in the timing of an epidemic. First, we simulated the model for a year (from week 26 of the starting year to week 25 of the following year) by varying the initial conditions and computing the center of gravity. Specifically, we varied $i(0)$ between 1×10^{-4} and 3×10^{-3} and $s(0)$ between 0.078 and 0.105. All other parameters were set to posterior median estimates.

To further understand how the shape of seasonal transmission term affects the degree of shift in seasonality, we varied the shape of seasonal transmission term by interpolating the estimated β_{seas} from Honshu and Kyshu islands, which are the two most populated islands. To do so, we first took posterior median estimates of β_{seas} from two islands and fitted generalized additive model with cyclic cubic spline bases to obtain smoothed estimates of β_{seas} for each island, which we denote as β_H and β_K , respectively. Then, we normalized seasonal transmission rates such that it has a mean of zero and has an amplitude of 1:

$$\zeta_X(t) = \frac{1}{\alpha_X} \left(\frac{\beta_X(t)}{\bar{\beta}_X} - 1 \right) \quad (8)$$

where $\zeta_X(t)$ represents the normalized seasonal transmission pattern in island X , and $\alpha_X = (\max(\beta_X(t)) - \min(\beta_X(t)))/2$ represents the amplitude of seasonal transmission

Table 1: Evaluation metrics used to analyze collective prediction dynamics.

Metric	Definition	Interpretation
Collective accuracy	$1 - \frac{\mathbb{E}[(Y - \hat{Y}^{\text{revised}})^2]}{\mathbb{E}[(Y - \alpha_0)^2]}$	Accuracy of the revised collective prediction relative to the baseline prediction α_0 .
Collective bias	$\left(\mathbb{E}[Y - \hat{Y}^{\text{revised}}]\right)^2$	Squared systematic deviation of the revised collective prediction from the true value.
Collective variance	$\text{Var}(Y - \hat{Y}^{\text{revised}})$	Variability of the revised collective prediction error across prediction events.
Human accuracy	$1 - \frac{\mathbb{E}[(Y - \hat{Y})^2]}{\mathbb{E}[(Y - \alpha_0)^2]}$	Accuracy of the human-only collective prediction relative to the baseline prediction α_0 .
Interest diversity	$\exp\left(-\sum_{i=0}^M \rho_i \ln \rho_i\right)$	Effective number of interests represented in the population.
Median AI belief	$\text{median}_{A \in N}(\beta_A)$	Median value of AI belief β_A in the population.

330 pattern in island X . This allowed us to interpolate between two normalized seasonal
 331 terms and obtain a flexible shape for seasonal transmission rate:

$$\zeta_{\text{new}}(t) = \zeta_H(t)(1 - \theta) + \zeta_K(t)(\theta), \quad (9)$$

$$\beta_{\text{new}} = \left(\frac{\alpha_{\text{new}} \zeta_{\text{new}}(t)}{(\max(\zeta_{\text{new}}(t)) - \min(\zeta_{\text{new}}(t)))/2} + 1 \right) \bar{\beta}_{\text{new}}, \quad (10)$$

332 where θ represents the interpolation coefficient, such that $\theta = 0$ and $\theta = 1$ causes
 333 β_{new} to have the same shape as β_H and β_K , respectively and $0 < \theta < 1$ allows
 334 us to model counterfactual transmission scenarios that interpolates between two
 335 islands. Note that $\zeta_{\text{new}}(t)$ does not necessarily have an amplitude 1 so we divide
 336 it by $(\max(\zeta_{\text{new}}(t)) - \min(\zeta_{\text{new}}(t)))/2$ to ensure the amplitude of 1.

337 For a given value of the interpolation coefficient θ and seasonal amplitude α_{new} ,
 338 we simulated two outbreaks for a year assuming $s(0) = 0.078$ and $s(0) = 0.105$
 339 and computed the difference in the timing of epidemic peak. In doing so, all other
 340 parameters, including the mean transmission rate β_{new} , were fixed to posterior median
 341 estimates for the Honshu island.

342 Regression

343 We performed univariate quadratic regressions for the estimated transmission rates
 344 against mean specific humidity and mean temperature, separately, and computed R
 345 squared values for each regression. We also perform bivariate quadratic regressions
 346 for the estimated transmission rates using both mean specific humidity and mean
 347 temperature as covariates. The significance of regression coefficients was determined
 348 using two-sided t-tests at the 0.05 significance level.

349 We performed a linear regression between the estimated proportion of susceptibles
 350 at the beginning of each season (week 26) against the number of children attend-
 351 ing childcare facilities. For simplicity, the regression was performed using median
 352 estimates for the susceptible proportions. We did not have data on the number of
 353 children attending childcare facilities broken down by island level and so we used the
 354 national-level data instead.

355 Data availability

356 All data are stored in a publicly available GitHub repository ([https://github.com/](https://github.com/parksw3/perturbation)
 357 [parksw3/perturbation](https://github.com/parksw3/perturbation)) [?].

358 Code availability

359 All code are stored in a publicly available GitHub repository ([https://github.com/](https://github.com/parksw3/perturbation)
 360 [parksw3/perturbation](https://github.com/parksw3/perturbation)) [?].

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464 Contributions

465 S.W.P., I.H., and B.T.G. conceived of the study. S.W.P. performed the analysis and
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468 Competing Interests

469 The authors declare no competing interests.

470 Figures

Figure 1: **Observed changes in RSV outbreak dynamics in Japan.** (A) Relative RSV cases across 47 prefectures in Japan between 2013 and 2024. Relative cases, representing the relative magnitude of RSV outbreaks in each prefecture compared to RSV outbreak sizes before the COVID-19 pandemic, are calculated by dividing the raw cases by the maximum value before the COVID-19 pandemic. The red arrow indicates when the shift in seasonality occurred. (B) Estimates of center of gravity (i.e., the mean timing of an epidemic) across 46 prefectures, excluding Okinawa. (C) Estimates of the epidemic trough (i.e., the minimum number of cases in a season divided by the population size) across 47 prefectures. In panels B and C, the center (horizontal line), lower bounds, and upper bounds of the box plot correspond to median, lower quartile (25th percentile), and upper quartile (75th percentile), respectively. The whiskers indicate the range of values that extend up to 1.5 times the interquartile range beyond the lower and upper quartiles. Outliers, which fall outside this range, are plotted individually. (D) Time series of RSV cases across 5 major islands.

Figure 2: **Summary of SIRS model fits to RSV outbreaks across major islands in Japan.** (A) Comparisons of observed cases (points) across the five major islands and fitted epidemic trajectories (red lines). (B) Estimated periodic seasonal transmission rates. (C) Relationship between the estimated periodic seasonal transmission rates and mean specific humidity. Points represent seasonal transmission rate estimates across 52 weeks versus average humidity across 2013–2020. Blue lines and regions represent the corresponding locally estimated scatterplot smoothing (LOESS) estimates and corresponding 95% confidence intervals ($n=52$). Red lines and regions represent the corresponding quadratic regression fits and corresponding 95% confidence intervals ($n=52$). (D) Estimated relative changes in transmission, capturing the impact of NPI measures. (E) Estimated proportion of the susceptible pool. In panels B, D, and E, lines represent the estimated median of the posterior distribution ($n=8000$ posterior samples). In panels B, D, and E, shaded regions represent the 95% credible intervals from the posterior distribution ($n=8000$ posterior samples).

Figure 3: **An increase in the susceptible pool explains sudden changes in seasonality.** (A) Predicted effects of the proportion of infected $i(0)$ and susceptible $S(0)$ at the beginning of season on center of gravity. Points represent the estimated values for $i(0)$ and $s(0)$ between 2013 and 2019, showing the last two digits of a given year. The white vertical dashed line represents the $i(0)$ value used for simulating epidemic dynamics in panel B. (B) Changes in epidemic trajectories caused by an increase in the susceptible proportion at the beginning of season for a fixed value of $i(0)$. (C–F) Comparisons of interpolated transmission rates used for simulating the SIRS model, corresponding to each corner in Panel G. Black lines represent the transmission rates used for simulations. Gray lines represent the estimated transmission rates the Honshu island as a visual reference. (C) The estimated transmission rates for the Honshu island. (D) The resulting transmission rates for the Honshu island with equal amplitude as the Kyushu island. (E) The resulting transmission rates for the Kyushu island with equal amplitude as the Honshu island. (F) The estimated transmission rates for the Kyushu island. (G) Differences in peak epidemic timing when we increase the the susceptible proportion at the beginning of season from 7.8% to 10.5% using transmission patterns that interpolate the estimates for Honshu and Kyushu islands.

Figure 4: **Increase in the susceptible pool following the launch of the Comprehensive Support System for Children and Childcare in Japan.** (A) Direct comparisons between the estimates of susceptible proportion at the beginning of each season in each island (black) and the number of children attending childcare facilities in Japan (red). Points represent median from $n=8000$ posterior samples. Shaded regions represent the 95% credible interval in our estimates ($n=8000$ posterior samples). (B) Correlations between the estimates of susceptible proportion at the beginning of each season in each island and the number of children attending childcare facilities in Japan. Points represent median from $n=8000$ posterior samples. Error bars represent the 95% credible interval in our estimates ($n=8000$ posterior samples). Red lines and shaded regions represent the best fitting linear regression and the corresponding 95% confidence intervals.